# MCP

Title:
## It's A Girl Problem

Author:
## Josephine Kelly

© 2020 Josephine Kelly

Published by
MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS
U.S.A.

Permission for performance of this piece is granted for the purpose of performance in competition by middle school, high school, and undergraduate collegiate performers. Online, remote, and video performances are permitted for these purposes. Theatrical performance and all other kinds of public performance, whether broadcast, online, or on stage, are prohibited without prior written permission from Mushroom Cloud Press.

This script is authorized for competition only if the competitor or the competitor's representative, including but not limited to parent or educational entity, have purchased a copy of the script from Mushroom Cloud Press or an authorized retailer. The script must be presented with the cover sheet bearing the ISBN. Additional requirements for performance may be made by tournament and league rules.

League officials: please contact Mushroom Cloud Press to validate script purchase.

For all inquiries and to see our full catalog of scripts, visit
MushroomCloudPress.com

***It's A Girl Problem***

RUSSELL: (a normal teenage boy)

Snap out of it!

Look you just can't make me. It is my power – my life.

Knock, Knock. Who's there? Nana. Nana who? Nana your business.

It's a joke my sister told me at dinner.

To give you an accurate account of my problems would mean I have to understand it, acknowledge it, accept it.

Which I don't -...have a problem.

I am a Lacrosse Player. I am very active, and I don't need this right now. I train for speed - my father always says ***"****remember you have to have* ***explosive speed for both defense and offense maneuvers. Focus Russell Focus. Footwork behind the net."*** Our mascot is a Tiger - the New Haven Tigers. (chants) NHHS NHHS...I don't watch foot work videos any more – not here.

Here, (signals the place he is in) they watch other training videos...

One video says it's (the reason he has been placed) like spotting a tiger in the jungle. Tigers are very stealth and difficult to see and when you do – it's too late... Mauled. When I think of "mauled by a tiger" I think about surviving – but I don't think you do. Survive. I don't think I am the Siegfried and Roy of eating disorders. Look them up on the internet.

Knock. Knock. Who's there? Tank. Tank who? You're welcome.

Look, I just want what every other high school boy wants - girls - and there is nothing wrong with wanting to look good. I'm trying for a six pack – right here (pats stomach) just buff up. There is nothing wrong with that.

I have no idea what or why they are saying what they do, and I have thought about this hard. God, I hate eating with the family. It's like living under a microscope. I just want to tell my parents to shut up!

I am not sitting around watching TV. I'm active - busy. I run after dinner – I get my homework done. They (the doctors) say that it could be based on obsessive and compulsive school work. Hey, you try taking my schedule – AP Bio and Literature - Straight A's! And I am good at Lacrosse. So, I don't know what my dad's problem is.

College is just around the corner and I must be ready. I want to play Lacrosse in college – I think I'm good enough.

So, I blacked out... I just haven't been feeling well. It is not a big deal. They all are caught up - like those pictures that you look at and there is a hidden picture behind it? Only I wish they would stop staring my way. I am not out of focus.

It's a forced eating plan. No way. What right do they have to take that control away from me? They call me a perfectionist, but I say my brain is firing and my body is in sync and my power is beautiful. Why can't they see that? I am winning at it. There are good fats and bad fats – hidden sugars – I know about these things – this isn't a spiral down, its knowledge. It's healthy living. I weighed myself last night and again this morning, so I know what I'm doing. I know the calories and what I'm eating. I keep constant track of them. I don't need a forced eating plan!

So, I slam the door and just want to be left alone. I don't have a problem. I don't have a problem. I... start to cut myself.

I have to be Superman on the outside, but on the inside I feel like an empty shell. But this - I can control – this takes me out of my shell - the pain . . .

Snap out of it.

But I can't - So I cut myself. I don't know - cutting creates something inside me that is here and now and I don't have to think about my Dad and how disappointed he is in me... *State Championship son!* . . . And he hates me.

*Snap out of it! It's a girl's problem.*

He yells that just before I slam the door to my bedroom. (he cuts himself)

So here I sit in the New Haven adolescent psychiatric Ward for eating disorders.

Who am I? This can't be who I am... In my reading, I come across this story.

There was this boy named William Brooksbank. He was an athlete – like me – only he's a swimmer. He won a state championship at age 10. In this article, it had early pictures of his with these chubby cheeks, but as he aged you can see his face just get gaunter and gaunter. His skin just stretched tighter and tighter across the angle of his skull. He was this living skeleton. And his parents paid a fortune in medical bills trying to get him help. But at age 22 he just lied down and died of cardiac arrest. . . At the time of his death he weighed 55 pounds. 55 pounds...His dad said, he watched him commit suicide for 11 years.

I am not William Brooksbank... it won't be 11 years.

It would be easy to cut too deep... Let's not go there – Dare we make plans.

Instead let's talk about the Food Rules – yes - rules to literally live by. It is in the manual given to us when my parents dropped me off here.

1. Arrive on time – be in the dining room when meal trays arrive. There is this fifteen-minute window of medication time – where the cart would just come rolling in (makes the wheel sounds of the cart) and you could hear the sound of anxiety in every deep breath.

All the seating here is random and each day we must look for our tray. Random - unless they know you are tricky or new and then you would get a seat near the nurse.

2. Time starts – once everyone is seated the nurse would write the time on this white board – we would get a start time and the time we would have to be finished by. We had 35 minutes for each meal and 15 minutes for each snack. If you did not get your meal finished, then it is marked as incomplete.

3. Feet on the floor at all times – our hands visible on the table at all times. You get 1 napkin because you might try to hide food in one.

4. No hats, caps are to be worn – no clothes with pockets or book bags - really it said knap sacks but who says that? -because once again you can hide food.

5. We would leave our trays on the table with the napkin on it – if your napkin wasn't there you would get checked.

6. No food talk – ever – somehow those nurses could hear you say, "I like oranges." And their heads would pop in and you would hear *No Food Talk!*

7. No cutting of food into smaller bits. Like you can't cut a banana and put it on your toast. Some people have triggers about mixing food.

8. Eat your food in the correct order. Entree before dessert. Salad before or with entree. The exception is breakfast when fruit is not considered a dessert.

9. No unprescribed foods. Like the vending machine or coffee shop food.

10. No drinks can be brought in by family members.

The time I hate is post meal hour. We all have to sit in this room after every meal. If you had to go to the bathroom during the meal – Too bad – if you went during this time so did a nurse.

Then its therapy.

I mean they keep saying we wouldn't be there if we didn't need it. We wouldn't have been accepted into the program if we didn't need it. But that's crap. My dad put me here.

They say remember your goals – well, I don't have any goals, that my dad didn't give to me.

I am this shell. His shell. My dad stands on the sidelines of my life yelling for me to do better. Be better. (building in anger) Nothing I do is good enough or right enough or ...man enough...

My dad is afraid I'm a fag. Gay. Homosexual. This is a girl's disease. And I'm weak for needing help. I am a failure.

I wish my dad would just listen to me – just be able to hold the space. To be the man that could love me - for me. I don't have a problem. My dad does.

Anorexia nervosa is about shame.

Knock. Knock. Who's there? Police. Police who? Police stop telling these awful knock knock jokes!

(He makes one final cut to his wrist. Looks at his wrist and then turns it toward the audience and looks at directly at them.)

My parents went to see Siegfried and Roy at Las Vegas – I mean that was before the tiger got him. Look up tiger mauling on the internet. Once they get you, it's deadly.